How should you deal with the attribution problem when reporting on not-necessarily controllable indicators (outcomes)?

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Many people believed that merely reporting on improvements in an outcome measure (indicator) related to an organization, agency, provider, policy, or initiative proves that it has had an impact. This is because, in the case of a controllable indicator (e.g. an output), merely measuring that it has happened proves that the initiative made it happen, because the initiative controls it (i.e. it is attributable to the initiative).
However, this is absolutely not the case with not-necessarily controllable indicators (which outcomes often are). Because they are not completely controlled by an initiative, other factors may have made them occur. So, merely measuring that they have happened does not prove that it is the initiative that has caused them to happen. See When Impact Evaluation Is Needed Rather Than Just Measuring Outcomes Indicators Explainer (G5). Therefore, an indicator set that includes both controllable (e.g. outputs) and not-necessarily controllable indicators (e.g. outcomes) without differentiating these two types of indicators can be confusing for readers interested in assessing and attributing the impact of an initiative. There are two ways to deal with this problem.

The first is to always clearly identify whether your indicator list includes both controllable and not-necessarily controllable indicators. You can do this by marking controllables with an @ (i.e. they can potentially be used as accountability indicators). The reader can then know that if a controllable indicator has improved, it is the initiative that has made it improve. Whereas, they cannot know this when looking at an improvement in a not-necessarily controllable indicator.

A second, complementary approach is to not just report on the level of higher-level, not-necessarily controllable indicators (outcomes) but also to include some information on any informal or formal evidence about the impact of the initiative on such high-level indicators. In doing this, you are going beyond just saying that Indicator X has improved. If robust impact evaluation is available, this can be reported. However, even if more informal information on the impact is available, some purchasers/funders would like to see this included rather than having not-necessarily controllable indicator results reported.

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